

Asking for and giving advice

Teaching guide

Ask a focused question and offer a useful option.

Understand the distinction

Give enough context for the listener to understand the problem. State your goal or constraint, then ask a specific question: I have ten minutes. Which route would you suggest? Advice is normally uncountable: some advice, a piece of advice.

When responding, offer an option and a reason. Could can present a possibility; should can make a stronger recommendation. Ask a clarifying question when information is missing. Acknowledge limits rather than giving confident advice on something you do not know.

Compare the patterns

CONTEXT

I need to reach the station by nine.

State the goal and constraint.

QUESTION

Which route would you recommend?

Ask something the listener can answer.

OPTION + REASON

You could take the bus because it stops nearby.

Offer an option with a relevant reason.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the correction: Can you give me an advice?

- A. Can you give me some advices?
- B. Can you give me some advice?
- C. Can you give me a advice?

2. Which question is more focused: What should I do? / Which bus goes to the station?

- A. What should I do?
- B. Which bus goes to the station?
- C. Both questions identify exactly the same problem.

3. What should you do before advising if the deadline is unclear?

- A. Assume the deadline is today.
- B. Recommend the quickest option without asking.
- C. Ask when the person needs to finish or arrive.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. A learner needs a quiet study place. Which exchange gives a relevant option with a reason?

A. I need a quiet place to study. You must go somewhere immediately.

B. I need a quiet place to study. Try the loud music bar because it has live bands.

C. I need a quiet place to study. Where would you suggest? You could try the library because it has a quiet room.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. B. Can you give me some advice?

Advice is normally uncountable.

A: Advice is normally uncountable, so do not add -s.

C: Advice is not normally used with a; use some advice or a piece of advice.

2. B. Which bus goes to the station?

It specifies the information needed.

A: This gives no specific decision or goal. The bus question identifies the information needed.

C: Only the bus question gives a specific destination and information need.

3. C. Ask when the person needs to finish or arrive.

Clarify the missing constraint.

A: An assumption can lead to unsuitable advice. Ask about the timing.

B: The timing affects which advice fits the person's needs.

4. C. I need a quiet place to study. Where would you suggest? You could try the library because it has a quiet room.

The question gives the need; the suggestion and reason directly address quiet study.

A: This gives no specific option or reason and adds unsupported urgency.

B: The suggested reason conflicts with the need for quiet.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-44.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

A learner needs a quiet study place. Which exchange gives a relevant option with a reason?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.